taken overland to the Nile. Then they were transported down the Nile in boats to Alexandria. There were other routes as well. Some fleets, for instance, sailed all the way up the Red Sea to Aqaba. Goods would then have been transported by camel and donkey caravan through desert towns like Petra to Mediterranean ports like Tyre and Sidon.

There is a story that Cleopatra, when defeated by the Romans, had hoped to escape with her family to India. When Octavian attacked Egypt in 30 BC, she sent Caesarion, her seventeen-year-old son by Julius Caesar, to Berenike with a great deal of treasure. Before she could escape, however, she was captured in Alexandria and famously committed suicide by snake-bite. Meanwhile, Caesarion had reached Berenike and could easily have escaped to India. Unfortunately, he was convinced by his tutors, almost certainly bribed, to return to Alexandria for negotiations. Octavian promptly had his cousin murdered. Cleopatra's Alexandria, like Dwarka and old Madurai, now lies under the sea.

The *Periplus* tells us that ships sailing from Berenike to India went down the Red Sea to Yemen and then, dodging pirates, to the island of Socotra. The island had a mixed population of Arab, Greek and Indian traders. Even the island's name is derived from Sanskrit—Dwipa Sukhadara (Island of Bliss). This may explain why many Yemenis carry genes of Indian extract. From here, there were two major routes to India. The first made its way north to Oman and then across the Arabian Sea to Gujarat. Ships were advised to make this journey in July to take advantage of the monsoon wind.

There were many ports in Gujarat but Barygaza (modern Bharuch) appears to have been the most important. The port-town is at the estuary of the Narmada river. Treacherous shoals and currents made it difficult for ships to sail up the river. Therefore, the local king had appointed fishermen to act as pilots and to tow merchant ships to Barygaza port which was several miles upriver. The author of the *Periplus* almost certainly visited the area because he describes in great detail the impact of a ferocious bore tide in the estuary.